national citizenship. Modi hasn't criticized or distanced himself from the remarks. In Gujarat, once he had settled down, Modi did marginalize the VHP hotheads. As prime minister, he is faced with a similar challenge of reining in his own saffron brotherhood. Will there be a genuine outreach to the minorities or will that run counter to his original persona as the face of unapologetic Hindutva politics?

During the Ramzan month in 2014, Modi did not host the traditional prime minister's iftar. 'You know he doesn't believe in these token gestures,' was how the decision was explained by a PMO official. Instead, I was reminded by the official how the prime minister's Jan Dhan financial inclusion scheme did not discriminate between Hindus and Muslims. 'Our slogan is "Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas",' I was assured. Will that assurance satisfy minority groups who coexist uneasily between fear and radicalization?

Catchy slogans have been Modi's trademark—when he visited Kargil, he assured the soldiers on the border, *'Na khaunga na khane doonga'* (I won't take bribes, nor allow others to take bribes). A few days later, I met a senior bureaucrat and asked him whether he felt red-tapism and corruption had significantly declined in government. He just smiled: 'This is India, Rajdeep. Nothing changes overnight.'

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On 15 August 2014, Narendra Modi addressed the nation for the first time from the ramparts of the Red Fort. Only a year earlier, on Independence Day again, he had begun his audacious bid for prime ministership by virtually challenging Manmohan Singh to a public debate. Now the challenger was prime minister. Wearing a short-sleeved kurta and a red Rajasthani safa, Modi reverted to his success mantra in the 2014 elections —a masterful orator directly communicating with the voter. In an extempore speech peppered with ideas and an infectious energy, Modi spoke of himself as a 'sevak' and an 'outsider' in Delhi. He focused on sanitation and 'toilet building' as a national mission, and rhetorically asked,